

all citizens receive adequate food, housing, health care, child care, and education.”

“The incentive by the employer or the capitalist is to keep your wages low, while your incentive is to make more money because you gotta survive, and it’s an antagonistic relationship,” said Brandon Peyton-Carrillo, a member since 2013 and the national facilitator for the DSA Solidarity Economy Working Division. Peyton-Carrillo suggested abolishing the worker/owner relationship and allowing the workers to own companies and run them as a democracy.

Here’s an example: When I lived in New York, I’d accompany friends to the Park Slope Food Co-op, a grocery store that is owned and operated by the people who shop there. According to the Co-op’s website, there are 17,000 members who take turns working at the co-op in exchange for 20 to 40 percent off their groceries. The point is to participate in your community, get more affordable food, and be able to have a vote about the goings-on at the place where you buy your groceries. This is what the DSA would want for all sorts of services.

Seems great, right? But many people think it doesn’t work. In 2016, a Gallup poll revealed that 60 percent of Americans still believe in capitalism over socialism. My guess is it’s because they think they’ll be supporting other people who don’t work as hard as they do. Overthrowing capitalism honestly sounds exhausting. Some believe socialism requires a strike. If the workers stop going to work, production halts and the rich can’t make money. But then neither can the poor. And also some workers might just go to work anyway. There’s no leverage.

Peyton-Carrillo said lower-income and working-class people make the mistake of thinking there’s only one way to do things because that’s all they’ve experienced, and they believe that the people at the top must deserve their wealth. They bow to knowing their role, hoping to get crumbs from the table. But, he said, people should know there’s an alternative, one that has been part of society for a long time.

Knowledge is power, and knowledge, it turns out, is pissed off. There have been a few nights where I’ve paced in my pajamas going over how hopeless breaking the system is unless everyone gets on board—and getting everyone on board with anything political is a mess.